

TERROR ON TAPE
Video grab of the scene at the convention centre soon after the blasts, Oct. 29

KERALA BLASTS

THE AFTERSHOCKS

By Jeemon Jacob

For Kerala and the followers of Jehovah's Witnesses (JW), an obdurate Christian sect with some 50,000 followers in India, October 29 was a black Sunday. As a 2,500-strong congregation of the sect rose for prayers at the Samra Convention Centre in Kalamassery, a Kochi suburb, a series of four explosions ripped through the hall, the first at 9.38 am, sending the faithful screaming to the exits. Three people died—Leyona Paulose, 55, on the spot; Kumari Pushpan, 53, and Libina Pradeepan, 12, in hospital. Some 52 were injured, at least five critically.

The incident fed right into a volatile environment in Kerala and the country in the wake of Israel's bombing of Gaza, and soon took on a life much larger than itself. Coming as it did right after pro-Palestine protests in Kozhikode on October 26 and the furore over a Hamas leader virtually addressing another rally in Malappuram, rumours ascribing the blasts to the hand of radical Islamist organisations went viral. But just hours afterwards, before matters spiralled further out of control, Dominic Martin, 57, a former JW member, came out and claimed authorship through a video message posted on Facebook. It was both a fortuitous anti-climax and a curious turn in itself. Why did he resort to violence? He said it was because the sect's ideology was "anti-national". He